

Yale has been building a Caribbean Studies program for 75 years. It just won't say so.

Antonio Padilla, Class of 2027

In the 1950s, the anthropologist Sidney Mintz arrived at Yale and was set out, in his own words, "to build a Caribbean program without saying so."

He built the Yale Antilles Research Program, the Yale University Press Caribbean Series, and a body of fieldwork, beginning in Puerto Rico, that helped invent the modern study of plantation societies. He co-founded what became Afro-American Studies alongside Roy Bryce-Laporte, a Caribbean scholar.

None of his work produced a curriculum. A Yale undergraduate in 1965 could read Mintz's books and take his courses, but could not study the Caribbean as a field, because no such field officially existed here.

Seventy-five years later, Yale has assembled nearly everything a Caribbean Studies program would need. What it still lacks is the program itself.

More than twenty-five Yale courses engage the Caribbean, spanning history, literature, music, medicine and decolonization. The Beinecke holds substantial Caribbean archives, while Yale faculty lead regional research networks in public health and science. The courses, scholars and collections are already here.

Yet Yale has no undergraduate structure that lets students study the Caribbean as a region on its own terms. Latin American Studies requires Spanish or Portuguese at L3, leaving much of the Anglophone and Francophone Caribbean outside its curricular frame. ERM is an important intellectual home, but housing Caribbean Studies as a concentration within ERM would narrow the field to students willing to make ERM their major. A certificate can accompany any major, which fits a field already spanning the humanities, social sciences and sciences.

The lack of interest isn't the issue. Professor Albert Laguna's seminar on Bad Bunny enrolled forty-four students and filled within hours of registration opening. This fall, a group of us in Despierta Boricua, the Puerto Rican student group, surveyed the Yale community about a proposed Certificate in Caribbean Studies. [X] percent of respondents supported its creation. [X] percent said they would have declared it had it existed. [N] current students have already completed three or more courses that would qualify them for the certificate today, without knowing it, without any advising structure that could have told them their coursework added up to something.

None of this is from a lack of asking.

I spent part of this summer reading letters from 1973. In April, Frank Bonilla — founding director of Hunter College's Center for Puerto Rican Studies — wrote Yale President Kingman Brewster in support of Despierta Boricua's push for Puerto Rican Studies. The Center, he wrote, stood ready to help. In May, Luis Nieves, Dean of Student Affairs at Livingston College, Rutgers, added his support, pointing to programs already running at Brooklyn College, Hunter, Fordham and Livingston. That same month, a White & Case attorney appealed to his friend “King” Brewster on behalf of three Puerto Rican students, including Yale Law student Manuel del Valle, who had proposed a department and noted the twelve thousand Puerto Ricans then living in New Haven.

Yale suggested that the students seek outside foundation funding to support the program. Yes, one of the wealthiest universities in the world was telling its own students that, if they wanted an academic department to exist, they would have to go out and find the money for it themselves: to fund, staff, and sustain an academic program. The students never approached those foundations, the funding was never secured, and the department was never created.

In 1982, Dean Howard Lamar announced Chicano/Boricua Studies concentration in American Studies, celebrated at the time as the first such program in the Ivies. It was inadequately resourced and dissolved.

In 2011, at a symposium held at the Whitney Humanities Center titled “What is Caribbean Studies?” Professor Hazel Carby observed that the Caribbean was an area that Yale didn't know. Fifteen years on, that remains true in the only sense that matters institutionally. A student cannot study it here as a field.

This year, Yale adopted a mission statement: to create, disseminate, and preserve knowledge through research and teaching. But universities do more than produce knowledge; they also decide how knowledge is organized, recognized, and sustained. Naming a field is one way they make that decision. Thinkers such as C.L.R. James, Frantz Fanon, Édouard Glissant, Sylvia Wynter, and Kamau Brathwaite have transformed disciplines across the humanities and social sciences, yet the Caribbean intellectual traditions that produced them remain scattered across departments rather than recognized as a field in their own right. That absence is not merely administrative. To decline to name a field is also to make a judgment about what forms of knowledge are worth formalizing.

I am an MCDB and Linguistics major. I did not come to this through a literature seminar. I came to it because the questions I care about — how languages survive colonization, how ecological collapse and colonial infrastructure produce each other, why a hurricane in 2017 became a public health catastrophe — kept turning out to be Caribbean questions with no Caribbean framework at Yale to hold them.

A certificate is a modest thing. It asks for no new faculty lines, no new department, no new courses. It asks Yale to acknowledge what it already teaches constitutes a field, and to say so.

We are submitting our proposal to the Committee on Majors this December. The petition is open. If you have taken one of these courses, or wish you could have, sign it.

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You can read the full proposal here: [Yale Caribbean Certificate Proposal](#)

Sign the petition here: [Establish a Certificate](#)

Complete Survey here: [Academic History & Interest](#)